Almost Perfect: The Films of Billy Wilder

Midnight

Midnight
Director: Mitchell Leisen
©/*Production Company*: Paramount Pictures
Producer: Arthur Hornblow Jr
Screenplay: Charles Brackett, Billy Wilder
Original Story: Edwin Justus Mayer, Franz Schulz
Photography: Charles Lang Jr
Special Photographic Effects: Farciot Edouart
Editor: Doane Harrison
Art Directors: Hans Dreier, Robert Usher
Interior Decoration: A.E. Freudeman
Miss Colbert's Gowns: Irene
Music: Frederick Hollander
Sound Recording: Charles Hisserich, John Cope
uncredited
Executive Producer: William Lebaron
2nd Unit/Assistant Director: Hal Walker
Cast:
Claudette Colbert *(Eve Peabody)*
Don Ameche *(Tibor Czerny)*
John Barrymore *(Georges Flammarion)*
Francis Lederer *(Jacques Picot)*
Mary Astor *(Hélène Flammarion)*
Elaine Barrie *(Simone)*
Hedda Hopper *(Stephanie)*
Rex O'Malley *(Marcel Renard)*
Monty Woolley *(the judge)*
Armand Kaliz *(LeBon)*
USA 1939©
94 mins
Digital 4K

Now that the Thirties Hollywood cinema is being constantly explored by television, we are in a much better position to assess the varied talents who were working at this time. But certain key films have inevitably been overlooked, and one of the reasons for commenting on *Midnight* is that it brought together a glittering array of star names on both sides of the camera. Produced by Arthur Hornblow Jr., directed by Mitchell Leisen and photographed by Charles Lang Jr, it also boasts a script by Billy Wilder and Charles Brackett which now seems a model of its kind – barbed, sly, irreverent and constructed in such a way that the story is always being propelled forward as one lie gives way to another.

The plot, in fact, draws on a variety of well-worn theatrical devices (as well as the whole Thirties comedy tradition), yet it is all made to seem extraordinarily fresh and vivid due mainly, I feel, to Messrs. Brackett and Wilder who were then at the peak of their collaboration, working for Lubitsch as well as later with Leisen again, on *Arise My Love* and *Hold Back the Dawn*.

Hollywood has always been obsessed with the more ludicrous aspects of high society: European aristocracy with its penchant for easy living and easy spending crops up again and again in the Thirties – crumbling, lecherous princes and dukes living it up until the money runs out and made even more attractive by their apparent gentility and the aura of class that goes with it. Almost every character in *Midnight* is involved in some kind of deception – even Eve, initially the most innocent, allows herself to be bought because she is penniless and flattered by Jacques' attentions and Flammarion's material gifts. Brackett and Wilder capture this rapacious world in brittle, abrasive dialogue ('It does something to your face – it gives you a chin', says Eve to Hélène as the latter chooses a hat) and manage the many plot convolutions with practised ease and flexibility.

A good example is the ballroom scene where Hélène is all ready to expose Eve as an impostor when 'Baron Czerny' turns up and makes a great show of being reunited with his loving wife. Having apparently been presented with evidence that they belong to her own class, Hélène accepts the situation with acid resignation, muttering 'we nearly made a mistake' to her companion as she gives Eve an obligatory smile in passing. As the narrative progresses, Eve is compelled to construct an ever-growing pinnacle of lies which reaches a high point of absurdity when she is forced to make an imaginary phone call to a non-existent ailing baby daughter in Budapest and Flammarion obligingly answers from a nearby extension (thus providing Barrymore with his greatest moment, vamping away to Eve: 'It was a plain case of alcohol poisoning – we picked her up in the gutter', and then imitating the baby's voice for good measure). The scene is finally capped when, faced with Tibor's determination to expose the whole masquerade, Eve persuades the others that her husband is subject to strange turns and obsessions (a sad heritage of the Czerny line!), like believing himself to be a taxi-driver. Again, class solidarity wins the day and they all band together to help Eve with her 'family' trouble.

One of the great qualities of *Midnight* is its ability to point up these social mannerisms and attitudes without making a great issue of them – the film never takes itself too seriously and never descends into vulgar parody. With the

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Almost Perfect:
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Double Indemnity
Mon 19 Oct 18:15; Thu 22 Oct 14:30; Sun 1 Nov 12:10; Wed 4 Nov 20:35; Sun 22 Nov 15:10
Sunset Boulevard
Mon 19 Oct 20:45; Sat 7 Nov 15:00; Mon 9 Nov 20:30; Sat 28 Nov 12:00
Some Like It Hot
Tue 20 Oct 14:30; Thu 29 Oct 20:30; Tue 10 Nov 20:35; Tue 24 Nov 20:40
Ace in the Hole
Tue 20 Oct 18:15; Sat 21 Nov 11:40; Wed 25 Nov 20:40
The Lost Weekend
Wed 21 Oct 20:55
Sabrina
Thu 22 Oct 18:10
People on Sunday Menschen am Sonntag
Fri 23 Oct 18:40; Sun 8 Nov 15:30
Witness for the Prosecution
Sat 24 Oct 15:00
Ball of Fire
Sun 25 Oct 12:15; Fri 6 Nov 18:10
The Apartment
Sun 25 Oct 18:15
Mauvaise Graine Bad Seed
Mon 26 Oct 20:45; Sat 7 Nov 18:20
The Man in Search of His Murderer
Der Mann, der seinen Mörder sucht + talk
Tue 27 Oct 18:15
Midnight
Fri 30 Oct 18:10; Wed 11 Nov 20:50
Hold Back the Dawn
Sat 31 Oct 15:10; Sun 22 Nov 18:10
The Major and the Minor
Sat 31 Oct 20:45; Sat 7 Nov 12:15
Avanti!
Sun 1 Nov 18:00; Sun 15 Nov 18:00
The Spirit of St. Louis
Mon 2 Nov 18:00; Sun 8 Nov 11:45
Five Graves to Cairo
Tue 3 Nov 18:20; Sat 14 Nov 20:45
Billy Wilder: America's Witness with season curator Ruby McGuigan, film writer Christina Newland and author of *Mr Wilder & Me*, novelist Jonathan Coe
Wed 4 Nov 18:15
Bluebeard's Eighth Wife
Thu 5 Nov 18:00; Sat 14 Nov 15:00
A Foreign Affair
Sat 7 Nov 20:20; Mon 16 Nov 18:10
25 and Under: An Introduction to Billy Wilder
Mon 9 Nov 19:00 BFI Blue Room
Fedora
Sat 14 Nov 18:10; Sat 28 Nov 14:40
Irma la Douce
Sun 15 Nov 12:10; Mon 30 Nov 20:15
The Private Life of Sherlock Holmes
Sun 15 Nov 15:10; Sat 28 Nov 17:45
The Fortune Cookie
Wed 18 Nov 20:35; Sun 29 Nov 14:50
Kiss Me, Stupid
Sat 21 Nov 15:00; Fri 27 Nov 20:35
Thou Shalt Not Bore:
How to Write Like Billy Wilder
Wed 25 Nov 18:15 BFI Blue Room

exception of Don Ameche (who is rather too pushing and heavy and totally non-European), the cast extracts every possible nuance from the writing: Mary Astor, supremely cool and bitchy; Barrymore (much less flamboyant than usual and yet perfectly capturing Flammarion's worldly-wise guile: 'I don't know what we're falling into, but it's not butter'); Francis Lederer, the ultimate in suave Thirties seducers and of course, Claudette Colbert, at the peak of her comedy form, slopping around in the rain in her evening dress at the beginning and giving a little secret smile when she thinks she has successfully crashed a posh reception.

If one attempts to analyse Mitchell Leisen's contribution one is faced with that old Hollywood mystery: the direction seems virtually 'invisible', so what did he do? This of course, applies also to other major comedy talents of the period (Hawks and McCarey among them); all have differing preoccupations yet all are united by what may be termed respect for their material. They were fortunate in being surrounded by supreme technicians, writers who knew how to compose speakable dialogue and players who knew how to act. Leisen in *Midnight* fuses all these qualities into a totally professional whole, without imposing a distinctive visual style of his own. Even so the overall timing, the judicious use of tracking shots to break up long dialogue scenes, the cuts to reaction shots at precisely the right moment all suggest the presence of a totally aware and sympathetic guiding hand.

Coming at the end of a decade, it is now possible to view *Midnight* in the context of its times. Soon after, Hollywood comedy was to take a new turn with the arrival of Preston Sturges, the Wilder-Brackett partnership was drawing to a close with Wilder about to direct his own work, and the war was soon to initiate the 'escapist' comedy and the musical revue. Brackett, Wilder and Leisen brought to *Midnight* a unique combination of urbanity and invective which has lost none of its sting. And surely Oscar Wilde himself would not be ashamed of Eve's parting shot to Jacques before she goes off with her taxi-driver: 'You must never get married, dear – it would be so unfortunate for so many women'.

John Gillett, *Focus on Film*, September/October 1970